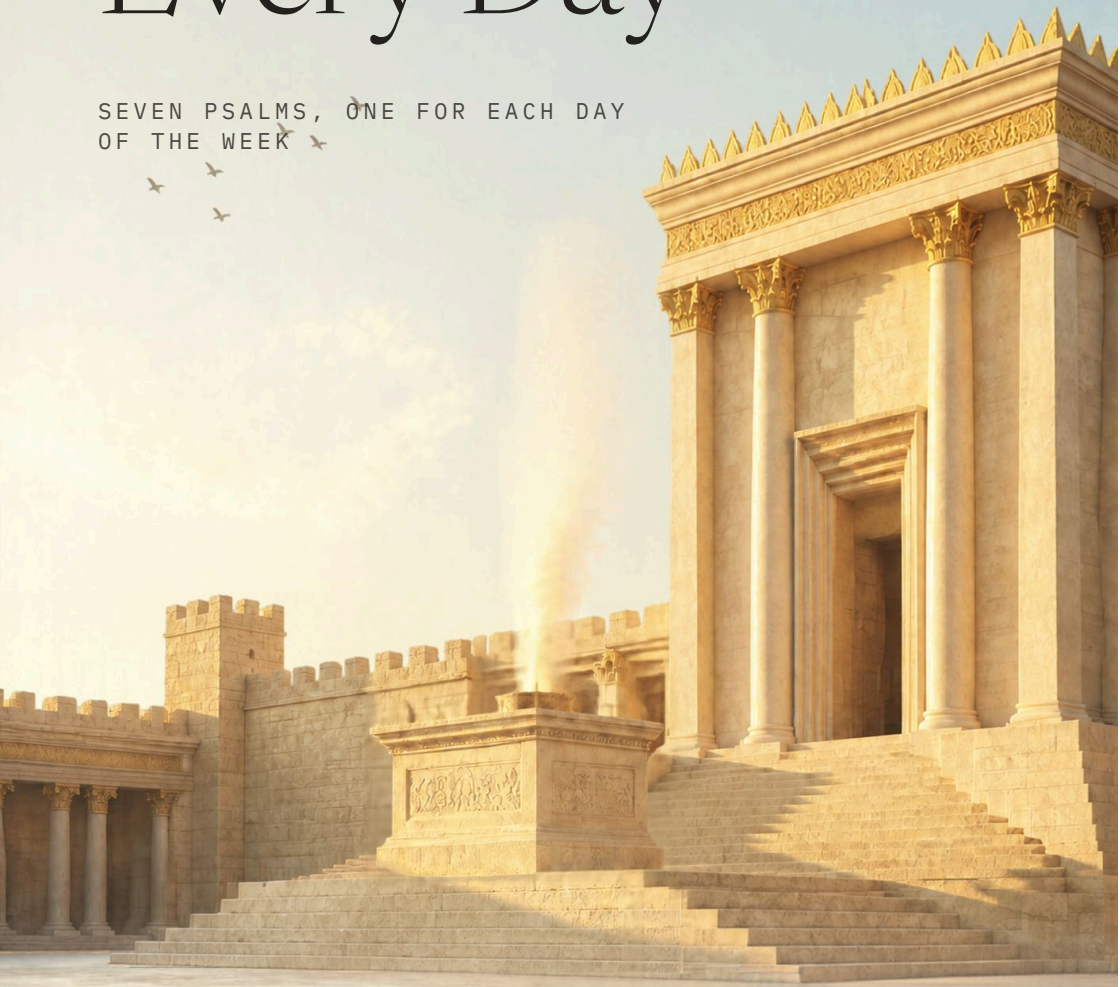
The Songs for Every Day

SEVEN PSALMS, ONE FOR EACH DAY OF THE WEEK



NORM REED



The Songs for Every Day

Seven psalms — one for each day of the week,
sung in the temple a very long time ago



for reading together

The one that keeps going

A very long time ago there was a temple in Jerusalem. Every single morning, and again every evening, the people there made an offering to God. They did it when they were happy and when they were sad. They did it when everything was going well, and they did it when everything had gone wrong.

They called it the **tamid**. It means *the one that keeps going*.

And while it happened, the singers sang. They sang a different song for every day of the week — seven songs, one for each day, the same seven, over and over, for hundreds of years.

Those songs are in the Bible. They are called psalms. Here they are.



SUNDAY

The day God said: this whole world is mine

Psalm 24

On the very first day, God started making the world. So Sunday's song is about who the world belongs to. Not to the strongest person. Not to the richest person. It belongs to God — the trees and the sea and the beetles and you.

> 1 The earth is Yahweh's, with its fullness; the world, and those who dwell therein.
>
> 3 Who may ascend to Yahweh's hill? Who may stand in his holy place?
>
> 4 He who has clean hands and a pure heart.
>
> 7 Lift up your heads, you gates! Be lifted up, you everlasting doors, and the King of glory will come in.
>
> 8 Who is the King of glory? Yahweh strong and mighty.

WONDER

The song shouts at the gates to open up wider, because someone very big is coming in. What do you think it felt like to be one of those gates?

A PRAYER YOU CAN SAY

God, this is your world. Thank you for letting me live in it.



MONDAY

The day God made a safe place

Psalm 48

On the second day, God separated the waters and put things in their places. Monday's song is about a city on a hill that was safe because God was there. Kings came to attack it, took one look, and ran away.

> [1] Great is Yahweh, and greatly to be praised, in the city of our God, in his holy mountain.
>
> [3] God has shown himself in her citadels as a refuge.
>
> [5] They saw it, then they were amazed. They were dismayed. They hurried away.
>
> [12] Walk about Zion, and go around her. Number its towers.
>
> [14] For this God is our God forever and ever. He will be our guide even to death.

WONDER

The song says: go for a walk around the city and count the towers, so you can tell your children about it one day. What is something safe in your life that you would want to show somebody?

A PRAYER YOU CAN SAY

God, thank you for the safe places. Please be the safest one.

TUESDAY

The day God said: look after the ones who get left out

Psalm 82

On the third day, dry land came up out of the sea — a place to stand. Tuesday's song is about being fair. God stands up in front of all the powerful people and asks them a hard question: why do you keep helping the ones who already have everything?

> 1 God presides in the great assembly. He judges among the gods.
>
> 2 “How long will you judge unjustly, and show partiality to the wicked?”
>
> 3 “Defend the weak, the poor, and the fatherless. Maintain the rights of the poor and oppressed.”
>
> 4 “Rescue the weak and needy.”
>
> 8 Arise, God, judge the earth.

WONDER

Who at your school gets left out the most? What is one thing you could do about it this week?

A PRAYER YOU CAN SAY

God, help me notice who is being left out. Help me be brave enough to go and stand next to them.



WEDNESDAY

The day God said: I can hear you

Psalm 94

On the fourth day, God made the sun and the moon. Wednesday's song is for when things are unfair and nobody seems to be doing anything about it. It asks a very good question: the God who made ears — do you think he can't hear?

> 3 Yahweh, how long will the wicked, how long will the wicked triumph?
>
> 9 He who implanted the ear, won't he hear? He who formed the eye, won't he see?
>
> 18 When I said, “My foot is slipping!” Your loving kindness, Yahweh, held me up.
>
> 22 But Yahweh has been my high tower, my God, the rock of my refuge.

WONDER

The song doesn't say everything is fine. It says God is listening. Is there something unfair you'd like to tell him about?

A PRAYER YOU CAN SAY

God, that thing wasn't fair. I'm telling you about it. Thank you for listening.



THURSDAY

The day God filled the world with singing

Psalm 81

On the fifth day, God filled the sea and sky with fish and birds, and the world got noisy. So Thursday's song starts with music. Then God says something sad: I had so much to give you, and you wouldn't open your mouth.

> 1 Sing aloud to God, our strength! Make a joyful shout to the God of Jacob!
>
> 2 Raise a song, and bring here the tambourine, the pleasant lyre with the harp.
>
> 6 “I removed his shoulder from the burden. His hands were freed from the basket.”
>
> 10 “Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it.”
>
> 16 “I will satisfy you with honey out of the rock.”

WONDER

Honey out of a rock — something sweet from somewhere you'd never expect. Has that ever happened to you?

A PRAYER YOU CAN SAY

God, thank you for good things. Help me not to be too busy to notice them.



FRIDAY

The day God finished, and everything held

Psalm 93

On the sixth day God finished making the world. Friday's song is the shortest of the seven, because there isn't much left to say. The sea roars and crashes — and God is higher than all of it, and calm.

> 1 Yahweh reigns! He is clothed with majesty! The world also is established. It can't be moved.
>
> 2 Your throne is established from long ago. You are from everlasting.
>
> 3 The floods have lifted up, Yahweh, the floods have lifted up their voice. The floods lift up their waves.
>
> 4 Above the voices of many waters, the mighty breakers of the sea, Yahweh on high is mighty.
>
> 5 Holiness adorns your house, Yahweh, forever more.

WONDER

Imagine the roughest sea you can. Now imagine somebody above it who isn't worried at all. What does their face look like?

A PRAYER YOU CAN SAY

God, when things are loud and scary, help me remember that you are not worried.



SATURDAY

The day for stopping

Psalm 92

The seventh day is the day God rested. It puts two plants side by side: grass, which comes up fast and dies fast, and a cedar tree, which grows slowly and is still bearing fruit when it is very, very old.

> [1] It is a good thing to give thanks to Yahweh, to sing praises to your name, Most High;
>
> [2] to proclaim your loving kindness in the morning, and your faithfulness every night,
>
> [4] For you, Yahweh, have made me glad through your work.
>
> [12] The righteous shall flourish like the palm tree. He will grow like a cedar in Lebanon.
>
> [14] They will still produce fruit in old age. They will be full of sap and green.

WONDER

Grass and a cedar tree are different in only one way: where they are planted. What do you think you are planted in?

A PRAYER YOU CAN SAY

God, thank you for today. Help me grow slowly and strongly, like a tree.

Every day

Nobody clapped for the tamid. It wasn't exciting. It was just the thing that happened every day, whether anyone noticed or not.

Most of the important things are like that. Brushing your teeth. Feeding the dog. Saying sorry. Being kind to the person who is hard to be kind to.

You don't have to finish this book. You just come back to it. Sunday's psalm on Sunday. Then next Sunday, read it again.